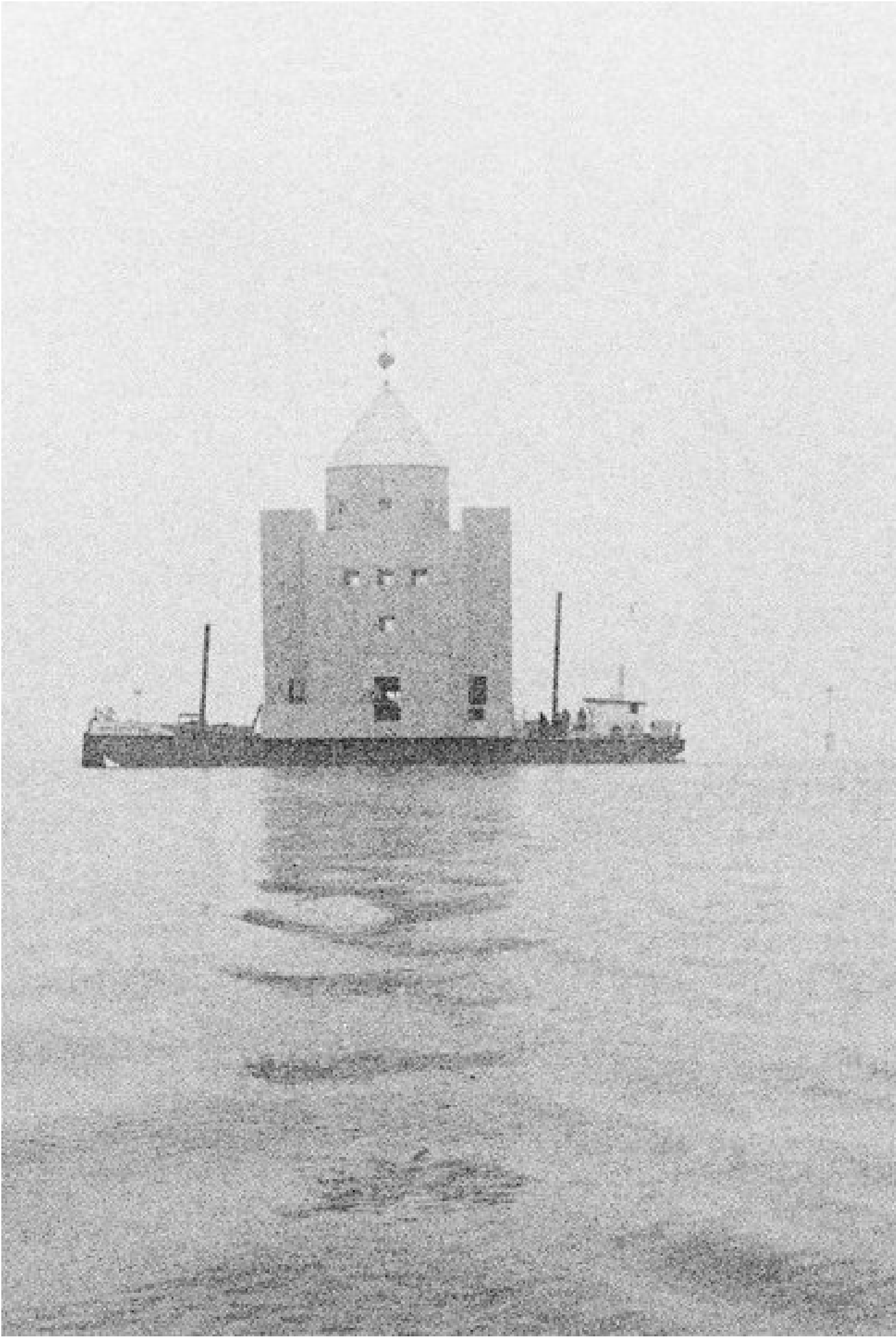




The Driftwood Theatre

Designed by Miabella Quirk

Designed by
MIABELLA QUIRK

Course
BACHELOR OF DESIGN IN ARCHITECTURE

University
UNIVERSITY OF SYDNEY

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2. Architectuul, Teatro del Mondo.

Introduction

This project proposes the design of a 250-seat theatre within Sydney Harbour, informed by Aldo Rossi's Teatro del Mondo (1980). The theatre is conceived as a distinct architectural object whose presence is amplified through its relationship with water, landscape, and movement.

A site within the harbour is to be selected. The theatre may be fixed in place, relocated seasonally, or designed to move with tidal conditions. The design should respond directly to environmental forces—light, wind, weather, and tide—integrating these elements into the performance experience, whether as a protected retreat or an exposed structure.

Access and arrival are key considerations. Audiences may reach the theatre by boat, ferry, or via a jetty extending into deeper water, with the approach forming part of the architectural experience.

The project also considers the theatre's impact on its setting, from active waterfronts such as Rushcutters Bay to more remote harbour locations. The theatre's program and identity are to be defined as part of the proposal, either focused on a specific genre or conceived as a flexible performance venue.

PART ONE:

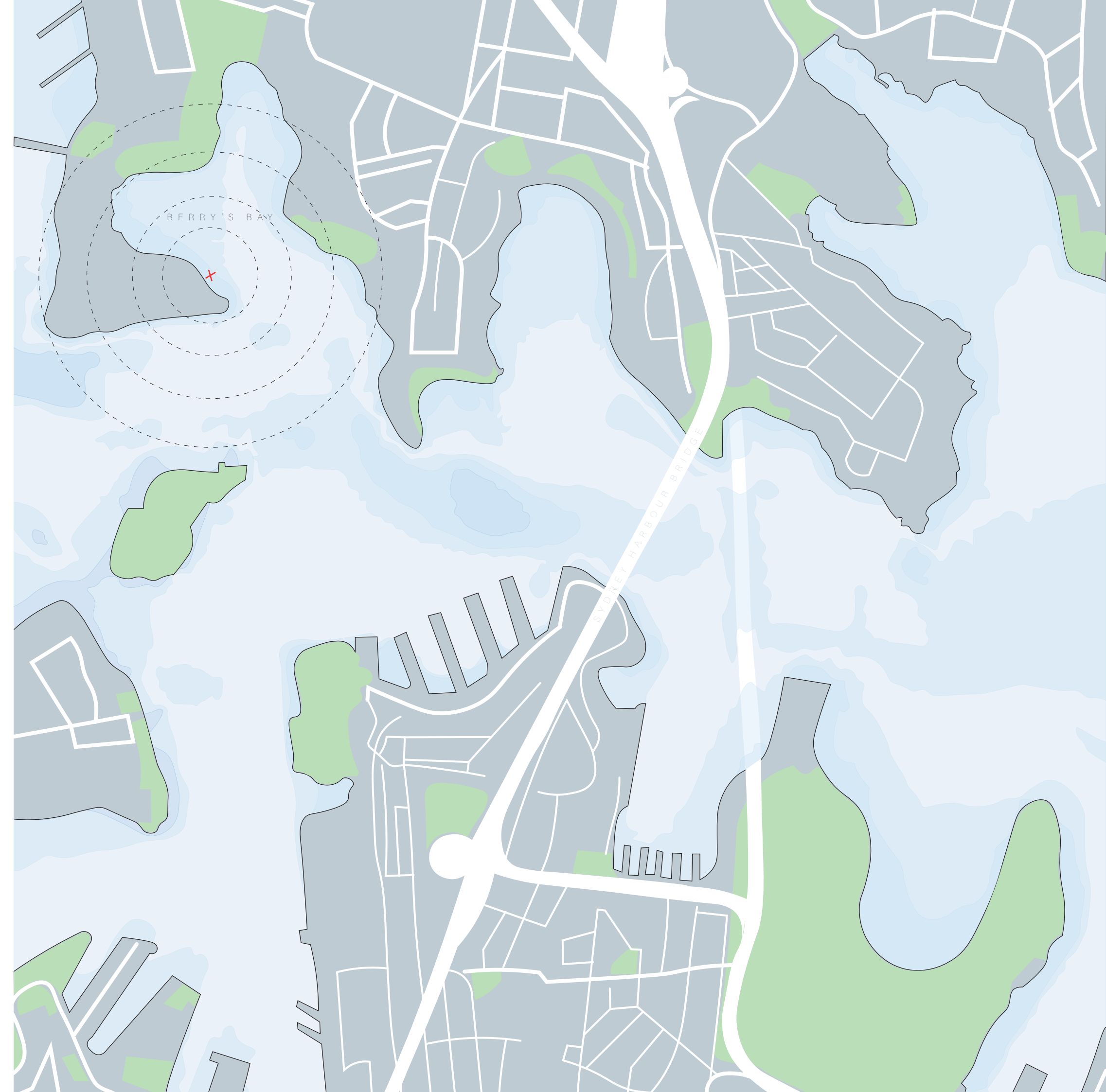
THE SITE

Site Selection

Berry's Bay in Sydney has a rich history shaped by its natural landscape, indigenous heritage, industrial past, and maritime traditions. The bay, located on Sydney's lower North Shore, was originally home to the Cammeraygal people, who used the bay's resources for fishing, hunting, and gathering. The area was named after Alexander Berry, a prominent Scottish-born merchant and entrepreneur, who acquired land in the early 19th century, stimulating European settlement and development.

In the late 19th and early 20th centuries, Berry's Bay became a thriving industrial and maritime hub. Shipbuilding, boat repairs, and maritime storage were scattered along its shores, reflecting Sydney's growth as a port city. The bay was also known for its timber yards, coal loading facilities, and warehouses, which supported Sydney's economy and harbour trade.

By the mid-20th century, the area's industrial activity began to decline, as did the health of the bay's water and landscape. Berry's Bay transformed as preservation efforts sought to revitalise and nurture the area's natural beauty and historical significance. Today, it is a blend of residential, recreational, and heritage spaces. Remnants of its industrial era remain in some preserved buildings and structures, offering a reminder of its maritime and industrial history while serving as a scenic retreat that reflects the layered history of Sydney's harbour.



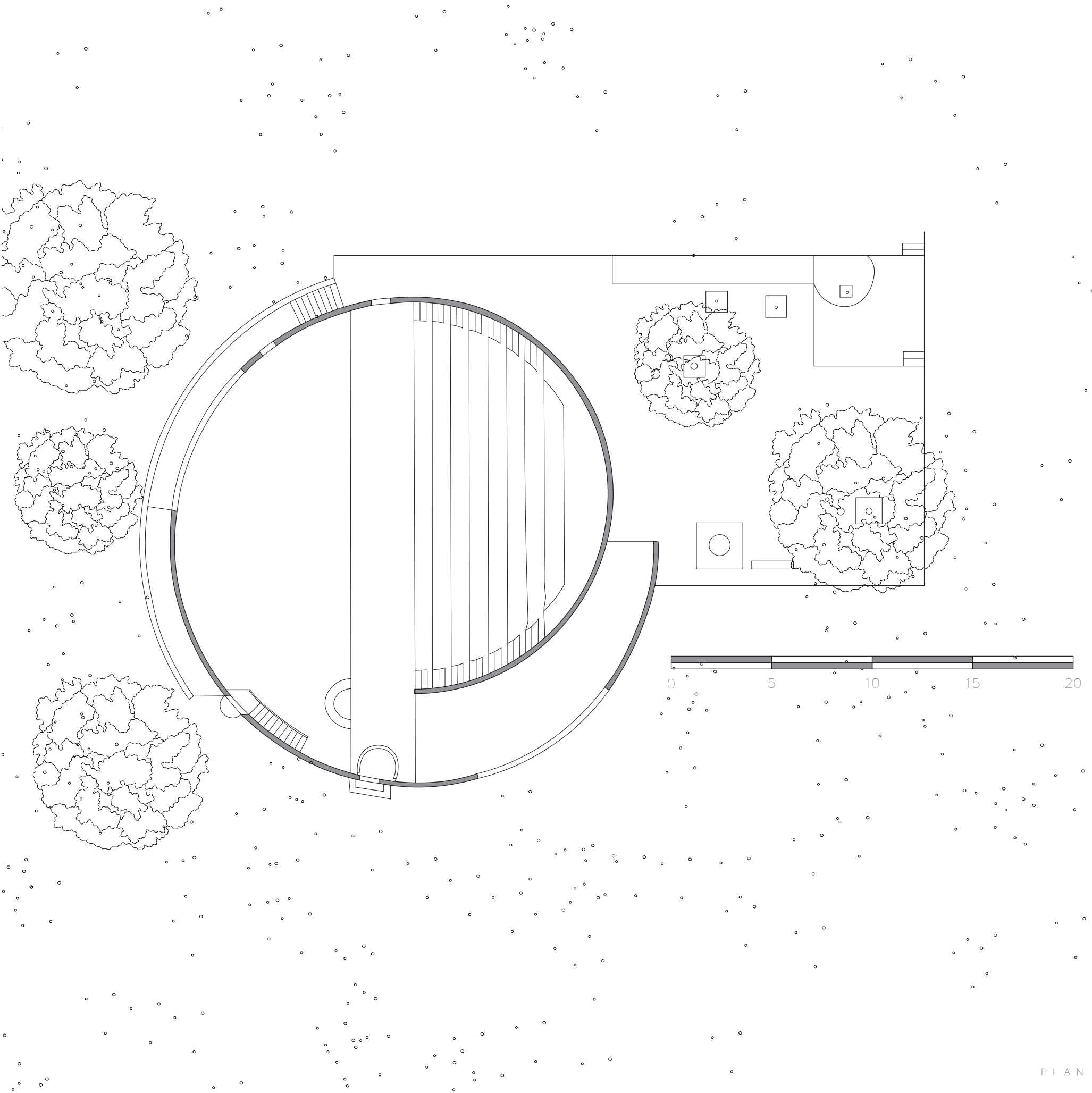
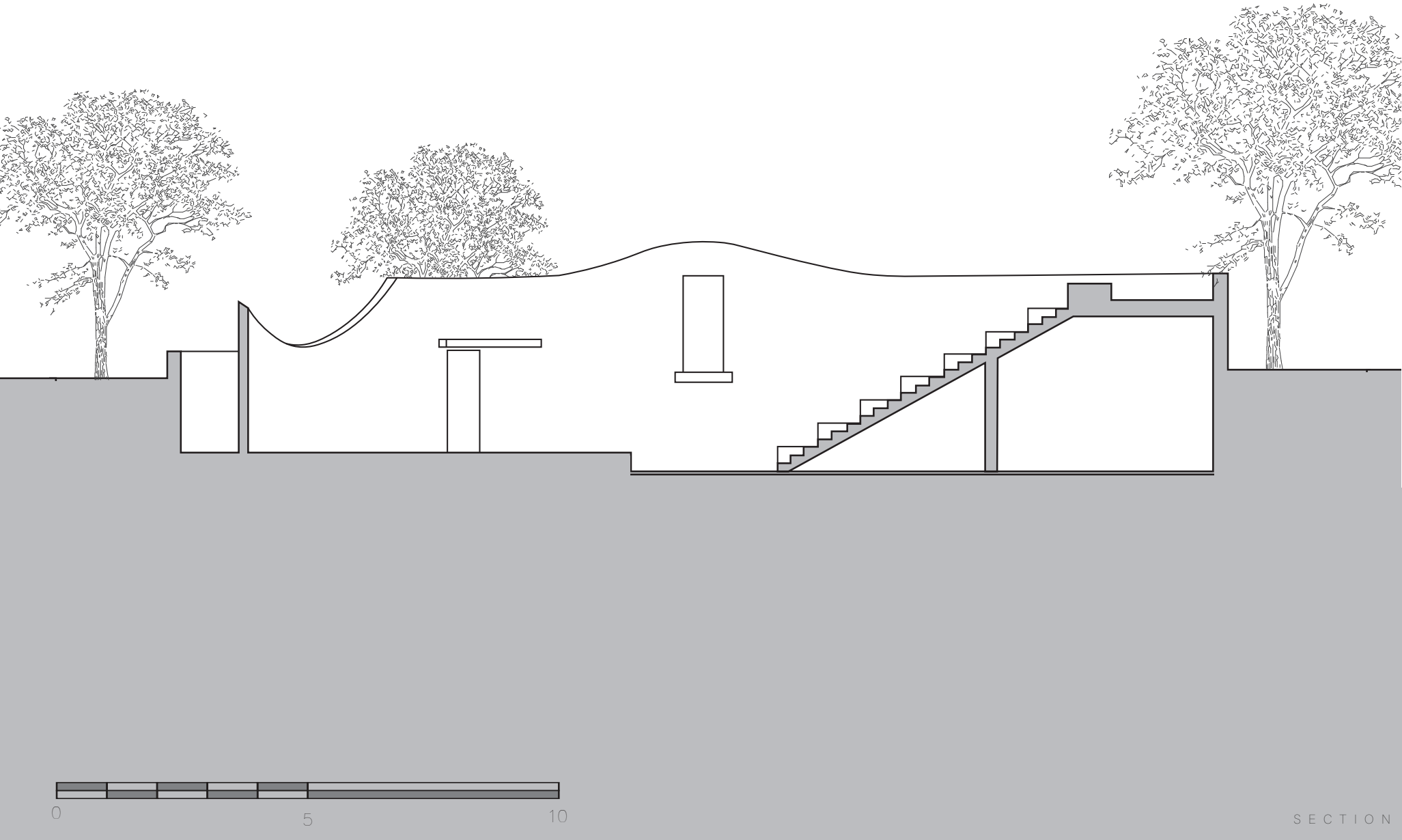


PART TWO:

THE APPROACH

Theatre Precedent Study

Jai Jagat Theatre
Designed by SEA LAB



Jai Jagat Theatre

The Jai Jagat Theatre was built to commemorate 100 years of the Sabarmati Ashram, founded by Gandhiji in 1917 near the Sabarmati River in India. Rooted in Gandhiji's educational philosophy of developing body, mind, and spirit, the theatre provides a space for the 1500 children of the ashram and nearby communities to practice performances, develop public speaking, work collaboratively, and express themselves creatively, all without having to travel far for rehearsals.

Surrounded by tall neem trees, the amphitheatre preserves the tranquil spirit of the place. Accessible via a shaded brick pathway that opens up to a plaza, serving as a foyer for events and rehearsals. From here, entry to the theatre is through a gap in a low, undulating white wall that spirals around the sunken stage. The design also includes a 70,000-liter rainwater tank beneath the stage to irrigate the native trees planted nearby, supporting both the environment and the ashram's sustainable practices.

Designed at a child-friendly scale, the theatre wall includes features like a Juliet balcony and stairs, which add playful elements to the performances. The structure, set partially below ground aims to blend with the landscape, reducing its scale and bulk. The lowering of the theatre and its undulating walls allows for community engagement in a much more inclusive manner. These gaps encourage audience members to watch from outside, not needing to be invited in and decrease the restrictiveness and privilege often associated with theatre.



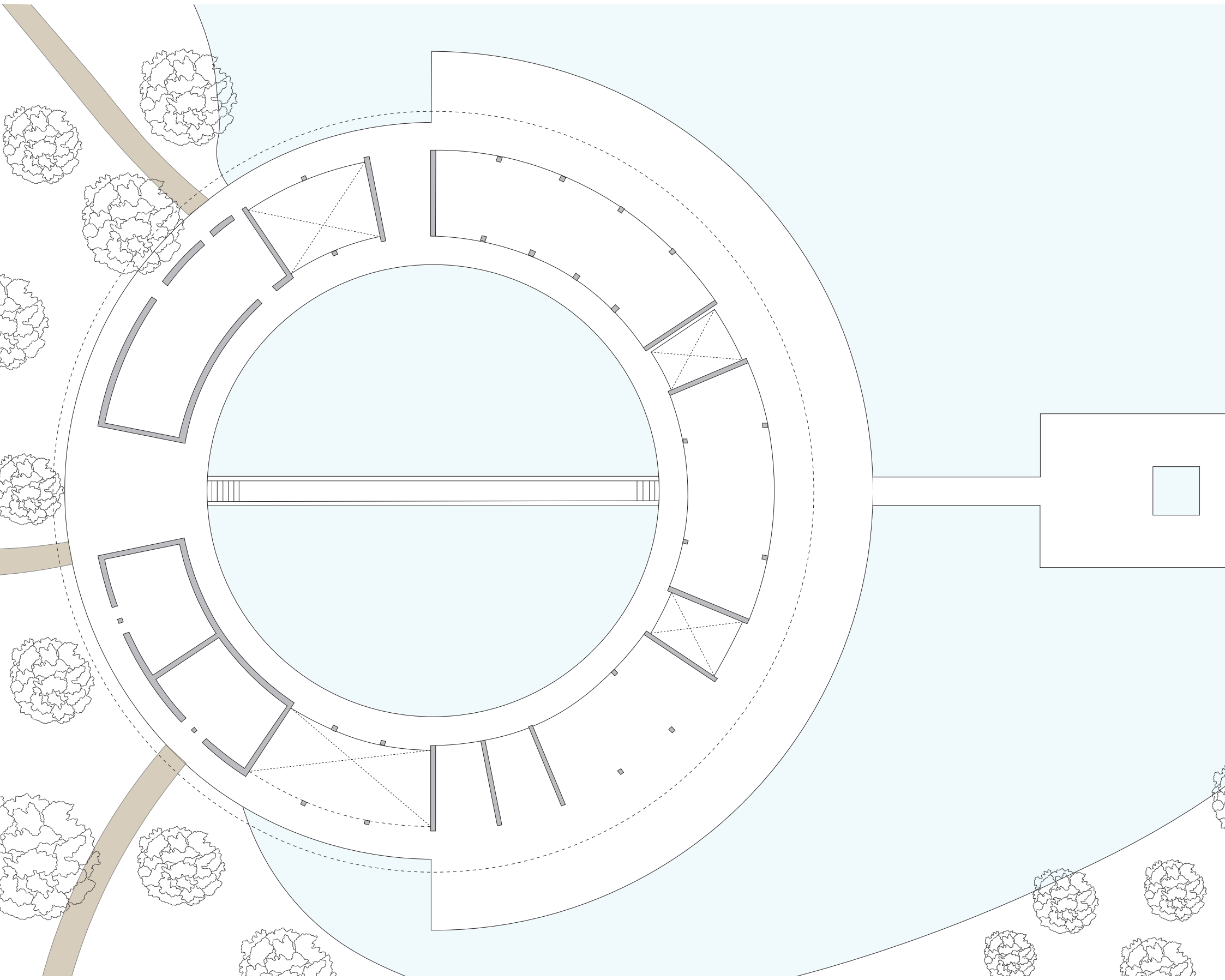
3. Divisare, Jai Jagat Theatre.



4. Divisare, Jai Jagat Theatre.



5. Divisare, Jai Jagat Theatre.

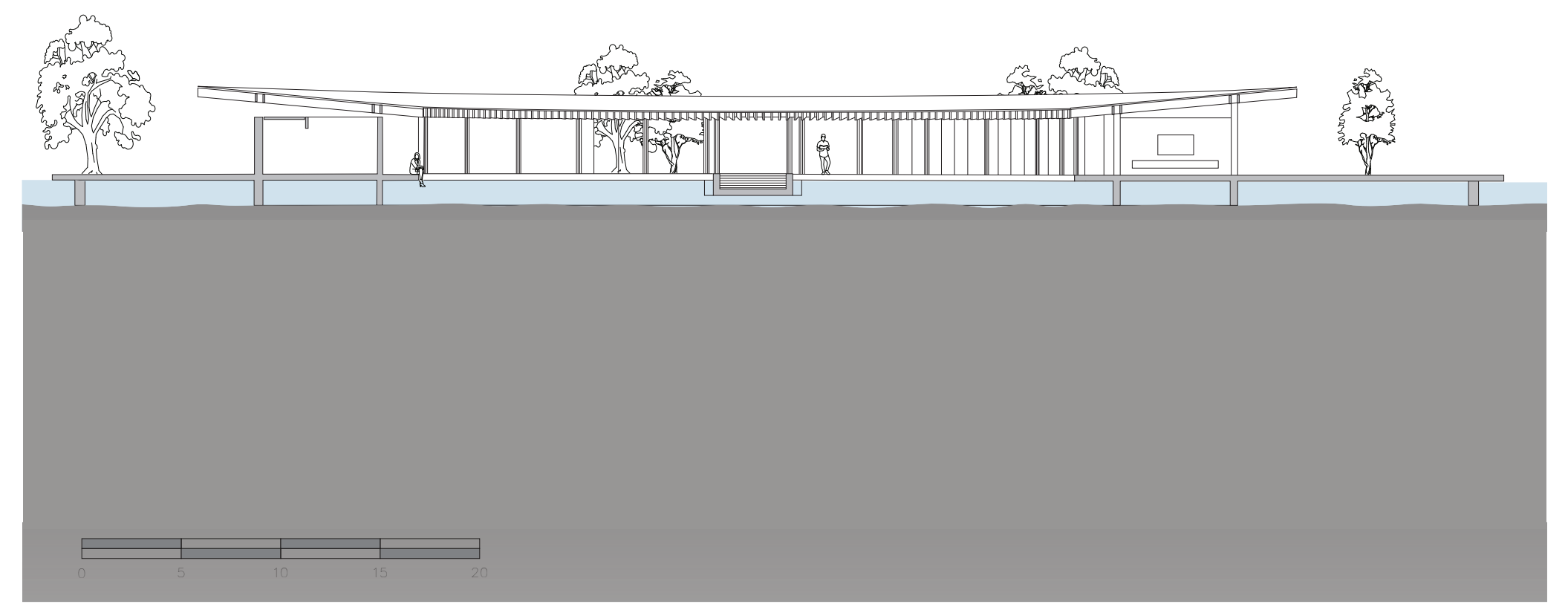


PLAN

'Floating Structure' Precedent Study

Clubhouse

Designed by Sordo Madaleno Arquitectos



SECTION



6. Divisare, Valle San Nicolás Clubhouse.



7. Divisare, Valle San Nicolás Clubhouse.



8. Divisare, Valle San Nicolás Clubhouse.

Clubhouse

Valle San Nicolás is a 370-hectare residential development near Valle de Bravo in Mexico, designed to blend seamlessly with its natural landscape. Centered on wellbeing and relaxation, the development features a Clubhouse and an 800-meter waterski lake, strategically placed to capture rainwater runoff at the site's lowest point.

Inspired by a boat anchored in the lake, the Clubhouse is arranged with a circular layout divided into zones for social and leisure activities. Two concentric rings offer nearly 360-degree views of the landscape, with a central passage leading to the main deck, bar, TV room, and floating pool. The east side holds dining areas and kitchen facilities, while the west includes a gym, spa cabins, and steam rooms.

The ways in which the walls and columns are strategically arranged allow for varying degrees of permeability into the spaces. This allows for different views to be appreciated and for the porousness to indicate how each area is used.

Constructed with cross-laminated timber (CLT) and framed with stone walls, the Clubhouse features natural materials like Kebony wood decking, volcanic stone, and an American red oak roof, creating a warm connection with the surrounding environment.

Assembling a Narrative

This initial collage captures key aspects of the site to help set the scene and approach the project with sensitivity.

The background incorporates vintage sketches depicting the site's historical reliance on the naval industry, showing the once-extensive jetties that stretched into the bay. It also highlights the water and soil pollution from this era, an ongoing challenge this design aims to address. The collage further references the reserve currently framing the site with its natural beauty, touching on the area's ancient Aboriginal heritage.



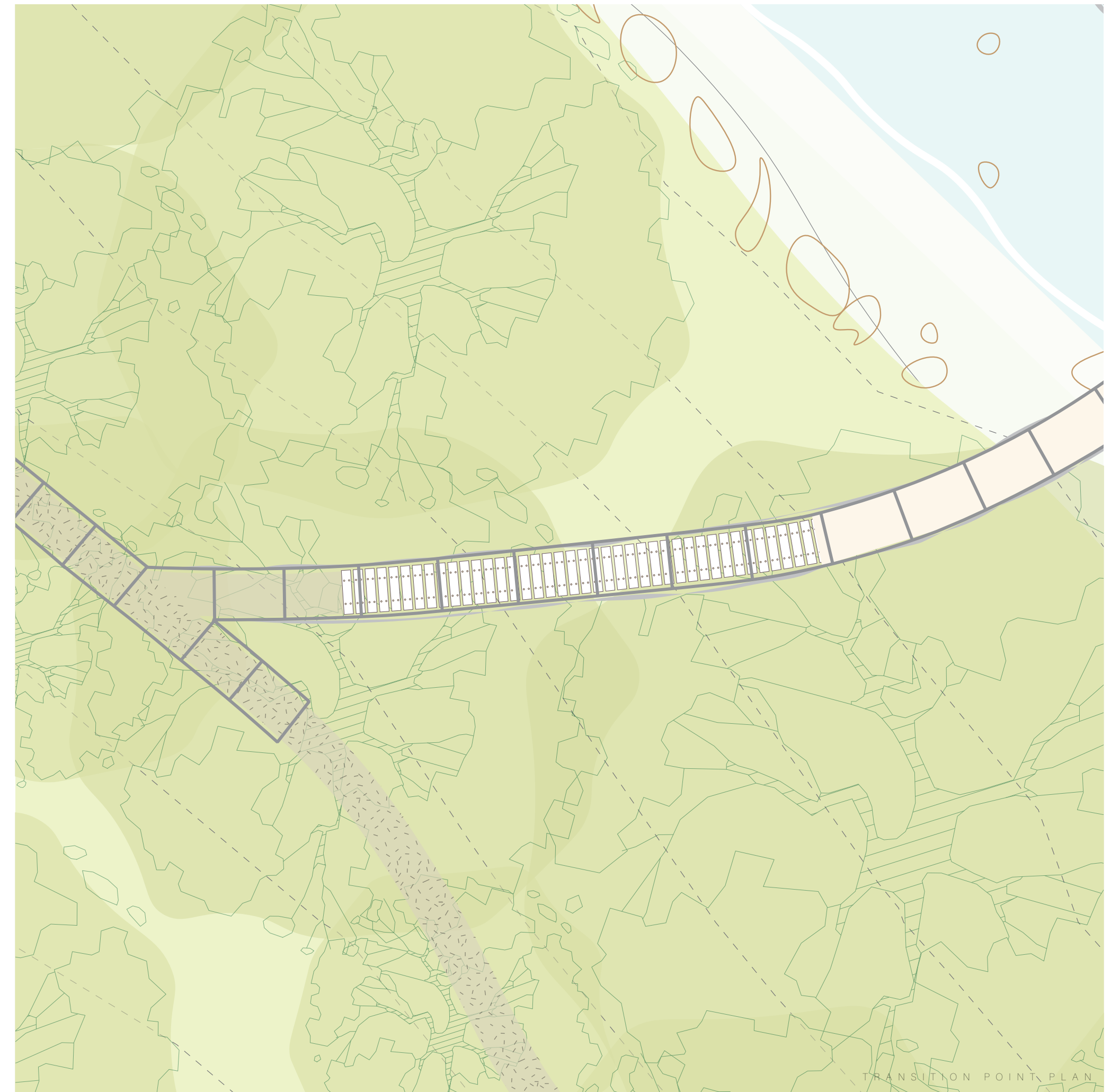


The Discovery

The existing landscape from which this building is set consists of primarily a large bushy reserve. This reserve contains a handful of walking tracks, along which visitors can discover different sites, catching glimpses of the bay before finding lookouts to admire it from. These walking tracks are documented and advertised very little, with most people stumbling on them by accident. The natural wonders hidden amongst the trees inspired this entry sequence, allowing the theatre to become another hidden gem to discover.

The journey to The Driftline Theatre begins as an immersive, unassuming walk along natural trails through the dense reserve. Initially, there's little indication of what lies ahead—just quiet, sandy paths and native bushland. But soon, subtle cues suggest a shift in the landscape: a simple metal frame rises above the path, a subtle threshold leading into a different space. Strips of cloth start to appear, suspended from the frame, hanging in loose intervals and gently swaying in the breeze. As the ground underfoot transitions from dirt to a narrow boardwalk, the cloth strips become denser, layering hints of concealment and intrigue.

Nearing the water's edge, a sturdy fabric canopy begins to stretch across the top of the frame, signaling the final approach. Emerging from the foliage and onto the floating structure, visitors encounter the theatre in its entirety, hovering just above the water. This gradual unveiling reveals the building as both a destination and a hidden wonder, harmonizing with its natural and industrial influences while allowing guests to feel as if they've uncovered a secret treasure of the reserve.

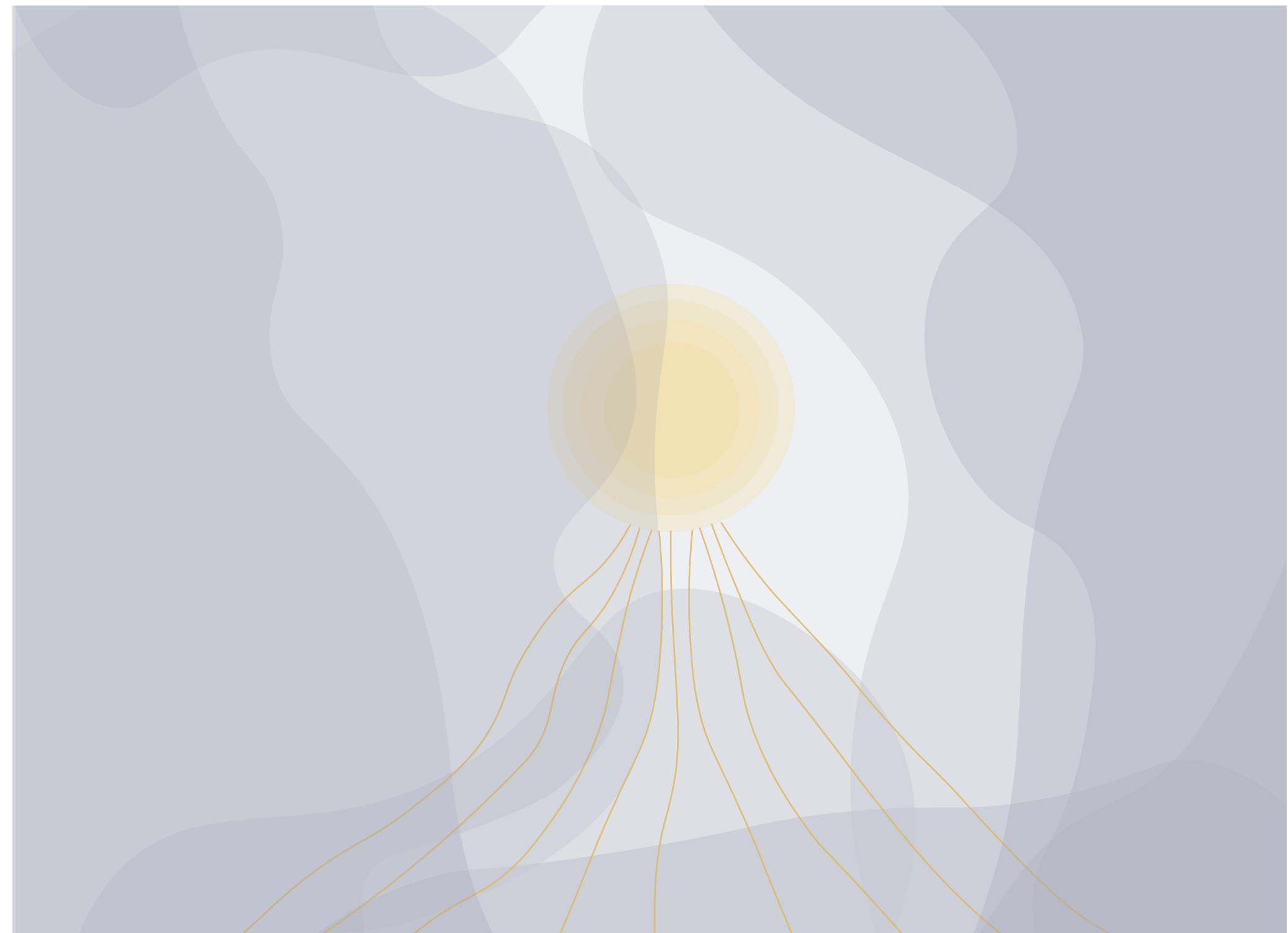


Conceptual Foundation



Community

Drawing from the theatre precedent, Jai Jagat Theatre, one of the main concepts driving this design was a sense of community. The theatre experience is often associated with exclusivity and privilege but this building aims to offer an alternative from its unassuming and welcoming entrance to its variety of local-led performances, breaking down societal barriers.

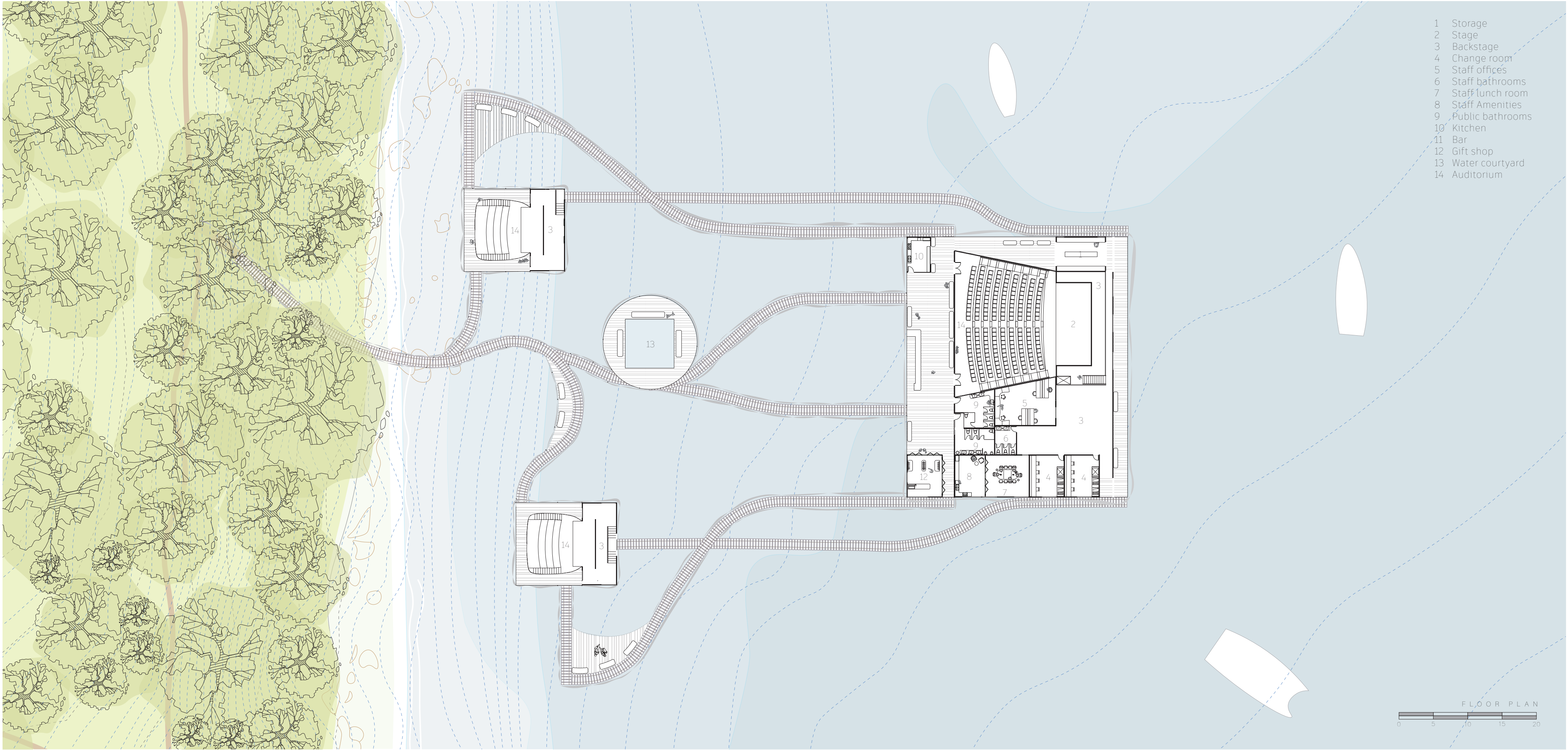


Discovery and Mystery

Drawing from the initial discovery of this site the themes of mystery, hiding and revealing play a large role in creating this structure, seeping into every aspect of it. It isn't designed to be on display, but instead a journey to take - uncovering different facets of the space the deeper you go.

PART THREE:

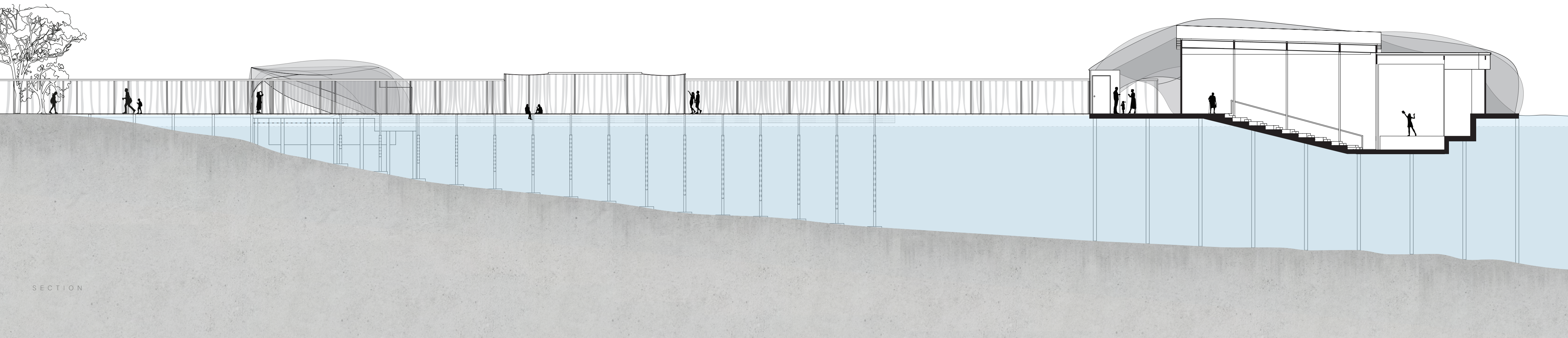
THE DESIGN



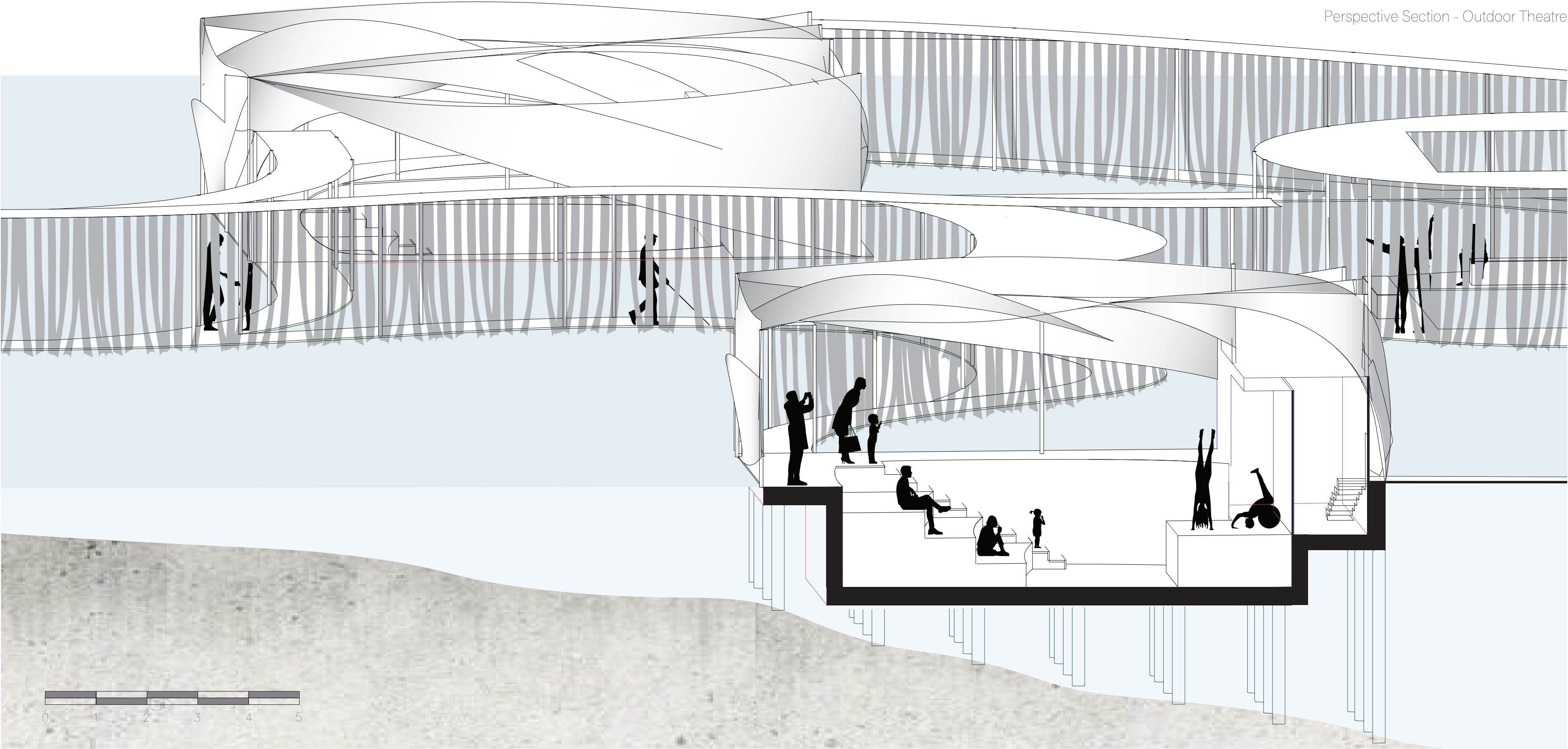
The Journey

As visitors finally step onto the water, they find themselves enveloped by strips of fabric swaying gently in the breeze. These strips become increasingly dense along the path, gradually obscuring distant views and drawing attention to the visitor's immediate surroundings. This intentional veiling of sight invites guests to engage their other senses fully— feel the wind, inhale the scent of the ocean, and hear the quiet lapping of water against the path.

This design fosters a heightened awareness and deep appreciation, allowing them to be immersed in these sensations as they continue toward their destination. The path is deliberately long and reflective, encouraging a mindful journey that honours the surrounding natural environment.



Perspective Section - Outdoor Theatre





Render - Water Courtyard



Render - Approaching the Main Theatre

PART FOUR:

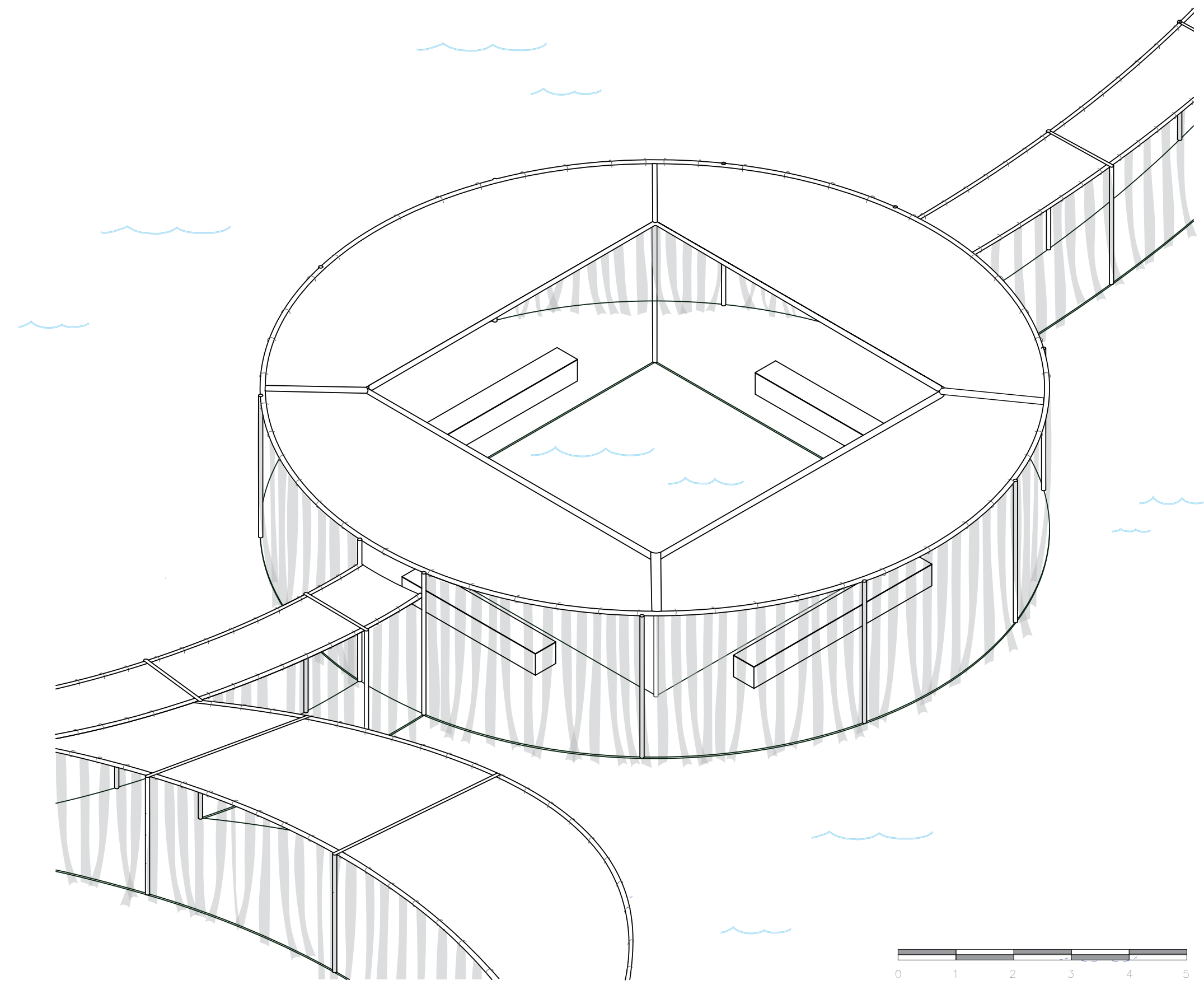
LOOKING CLOSER



Finding Driftwood Theatre

The journey to the water is an essential element of the design, introducing visitors to the theme of concealment and revelation. It leads them on an unexpected adventure, as many may not fully realise what they have stumbled upon. As the path winds through the reserve, glimpses of the water's edge begin to emerge, offering hints of the theatre.

Strips of fabric gradually appear, suspended on the frame around them, sparking curiosity and drawing them further along. This initial part of their journey is crucial to the experience, as they step onto the water, enveloped by the hanging fabric, still unsure of the hidden gem they've discovered.

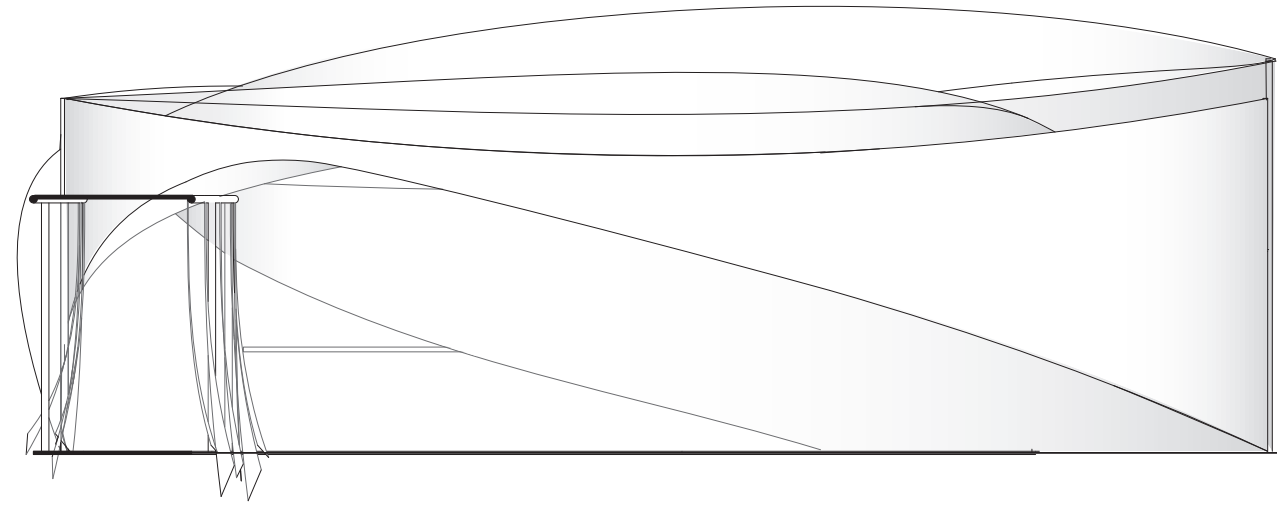


The Water Courtyard

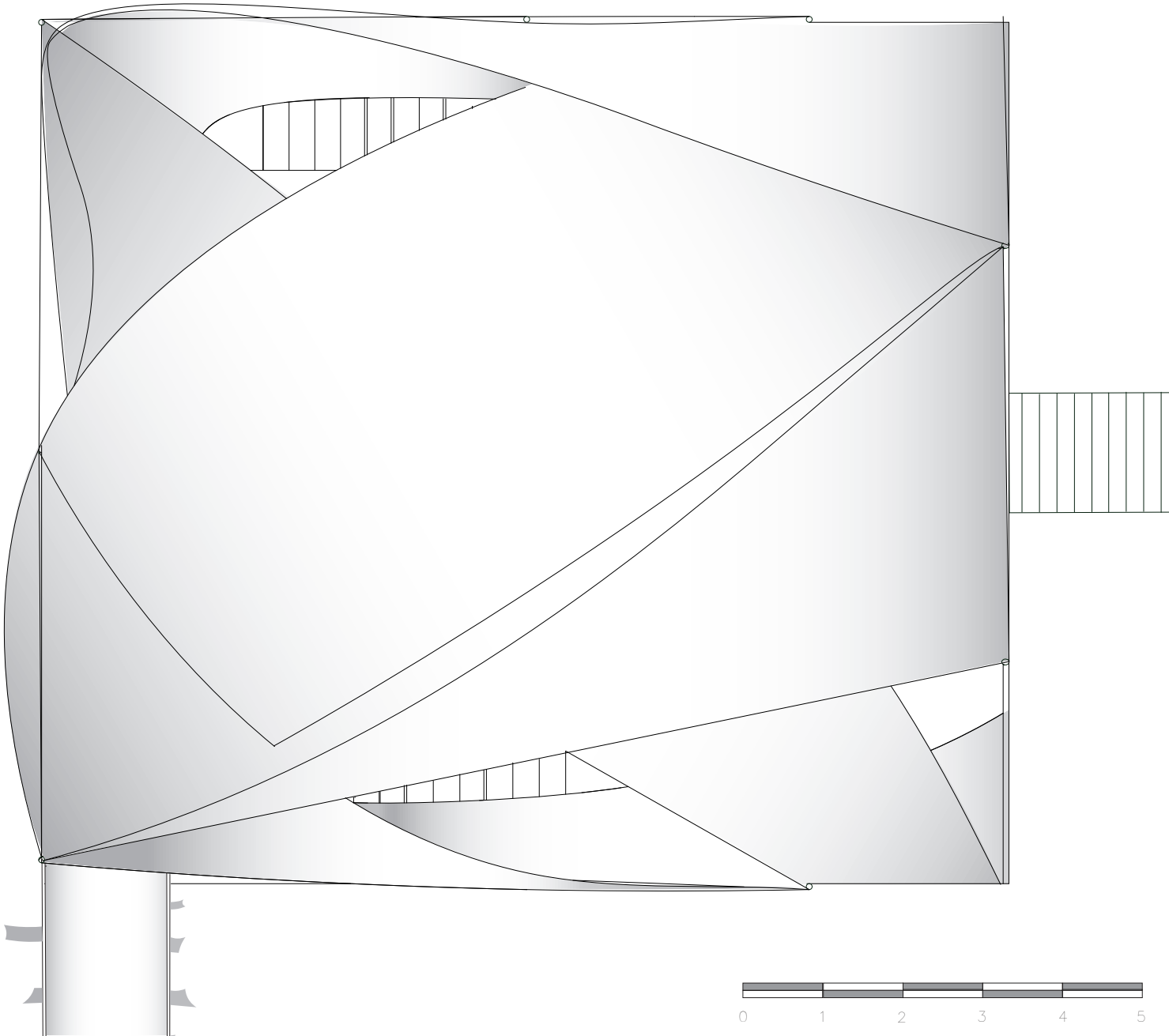
The water courtyard offers a serene resting point along the narrow path over the water.

Here, visitors can pause, choosing to sit on a bench or perch on the deck with their feet in the water, taking a reflective moment before deciding their next steps. Enclosed by strips of fabric that obscure much of the bay, their gaze is gently drawn inward—toward the company of fellow visitors and the tranquil square of water at the courtyard's center.

ELEVATION



ROOF PLAN



Community Theatres

These smaller theatres - as depicted previously in the perspective section - serve as a welcoming space for visitors to come across. With no barrier to enter, physical or financial, these spaces encourage onlookers to enjoy the show. Performances held in these areas are more community-focused than the larger theatre, showcasing local talent and smaller-scale acts.

The smaller theatres are primarily outdoors with only the thick fabric draped around the space to protect from the elements. Similarly to the larger theatre area, this fabric shifts and flows with the wind, revealing different elements of the harbour, engaging with the site as it takes the form of the breeze passing through.



9. ArchDaily, Pavilion and Workshops for Nature Concert Hall.

Fabric Precedent Study

Nature Concert Hall

Designed by DJA



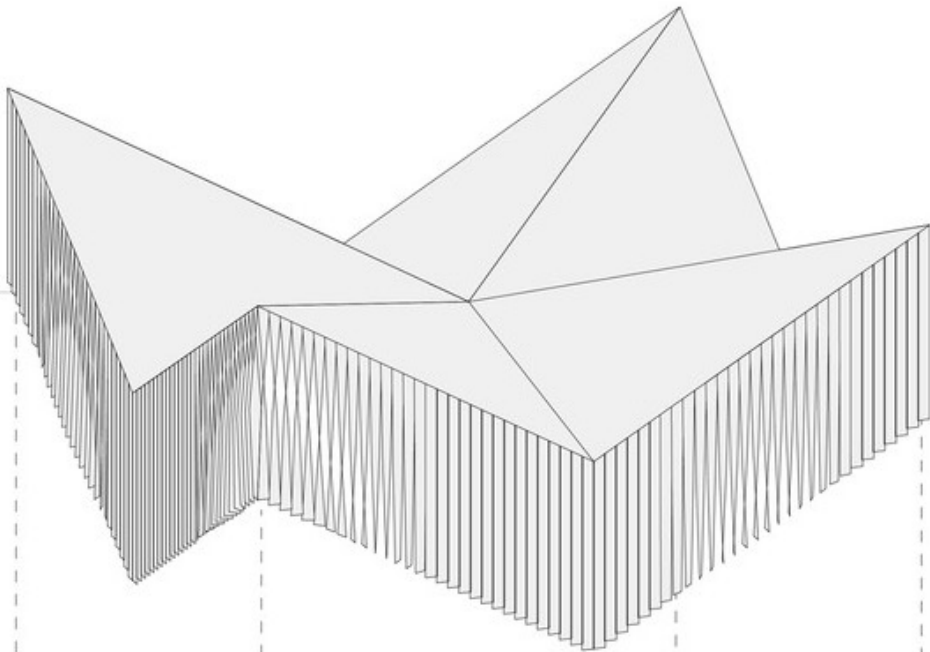
10. ArchDaily, Pavilion and Workshops for Nature Concert Hall.



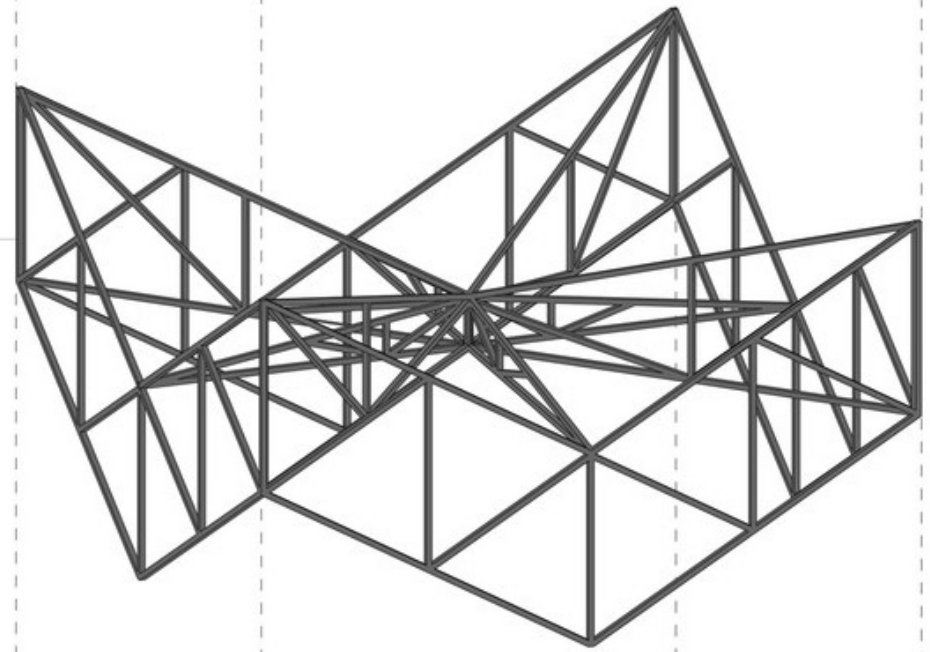
11. ArchDaily, Pavilion and Workshops for Nature Concert Hall.

Structure System

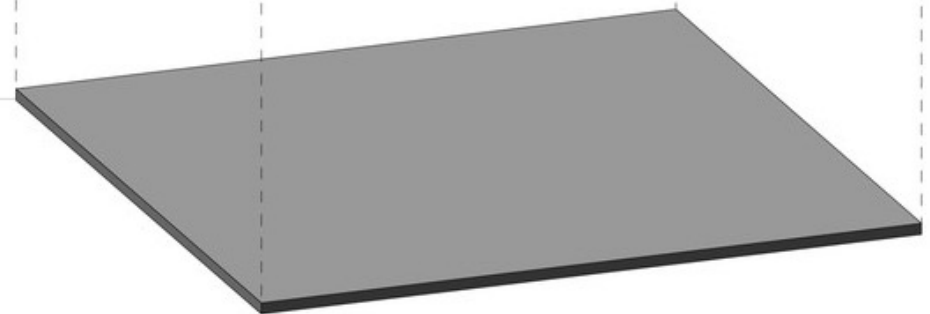
Fabric Facade and Roof



Structural Metal Frame



Base Platform



12. ArchDaily, Pavilion and Workshops for Nature Concert Hall.

The "Nature Concert Hall" pavilion is an immersive artistic installation designed to blend seamlessly with its natural surroundings, enhancing the experience through space, light, video, and music. One of the structure's primary objectives is to reduce the impact on the landscape it sits on, with the structure of the pavilion designed to minimise the number of points touching this protected biotope meadow. Under its roof, the pavilion hosts a 20-person chamber orchestra and a music band, creating an intimate setting for performances. Its elevations serve as screens for video and light projections.

The pavilion's modular structure allows for flexible reconfiguration of spaces, adapting to different needs. Each module is outfitted with vertical fabric panels that can rotate to adjust the sense of enclosure, creating a curated level of either transparency or privacy. This fascinating fabric system can appear to be moved by the wind, further engaging in the site - when in reality it is carefully prescribed. The fabric brings a sense of movement and fluidity to the structure that could otherwise feel quite industrial, allowing the permeability to intrigue the audience and add an element of mystery to an otherwise simple performance space.

This delicately orchestrated event aims to bring attention to the natural context - encouraging the audience to be careful and considerate allowing them to become aware of the beauty of nature.

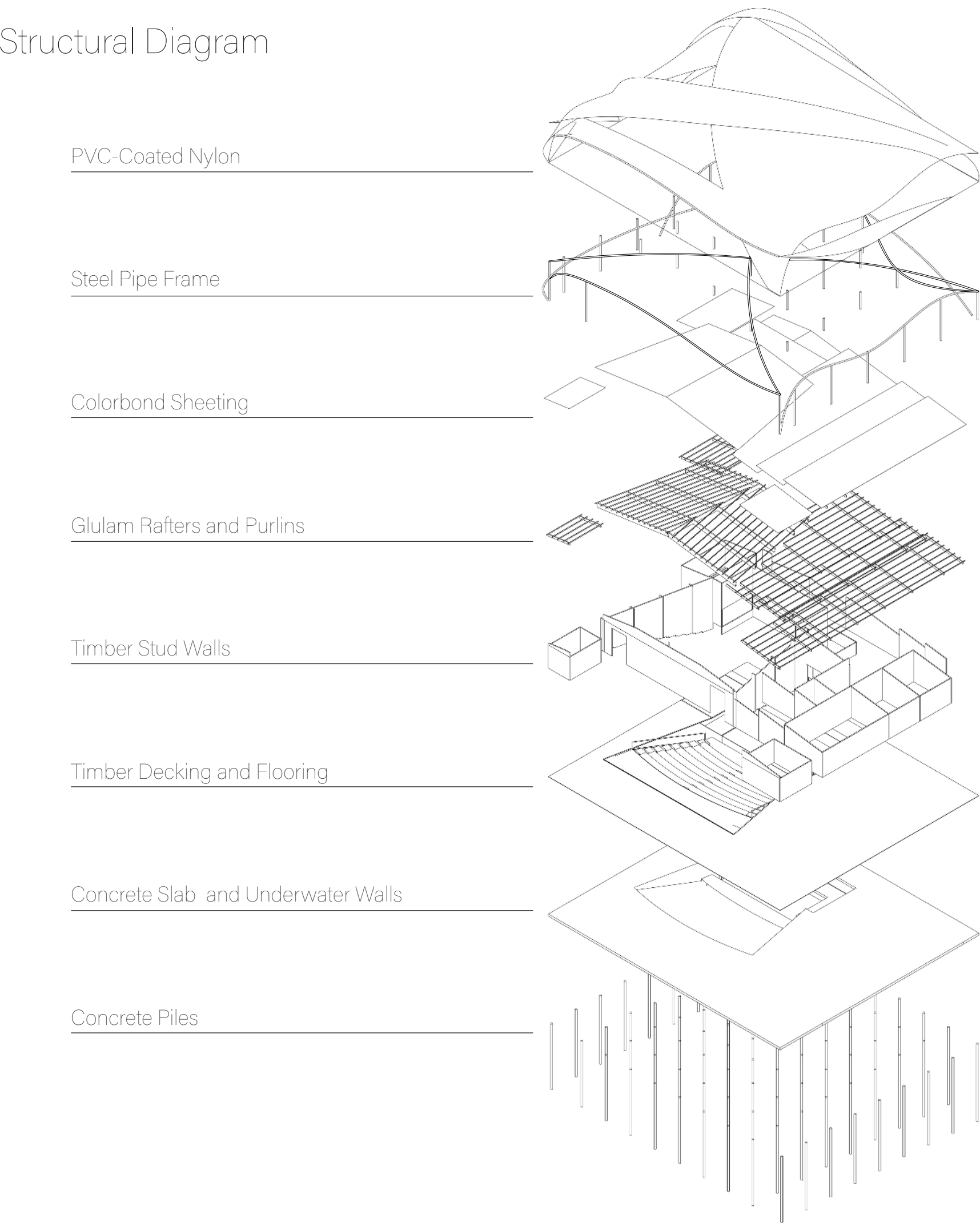


13. ArchDaily, Pavilion and Workshops for Nature Concert Hall.

PART FIVE:

STRUCTURE

Structural Diagram



SCALE 1:250

Structural Elements to Note

Fabric Structure

The fabric draped around the main structure is supported by a grid of steel posts secured into the roof at varying heights to exaggerate the undulating fabric. The fabric is left loose enough to allow for movement with the wind between each attachment point. In key areas, the fabric is supported by lengths of curved steel pipe, secured to the posts and ensuring crucial openings maintain their shape.

Concrete Barrier

The auditorium is sunken underwater to reduce the overall bulk of the building and reduce its visual impact. Due to this, the underwater areas are lined with the recommended thickness of concrete (320mm).

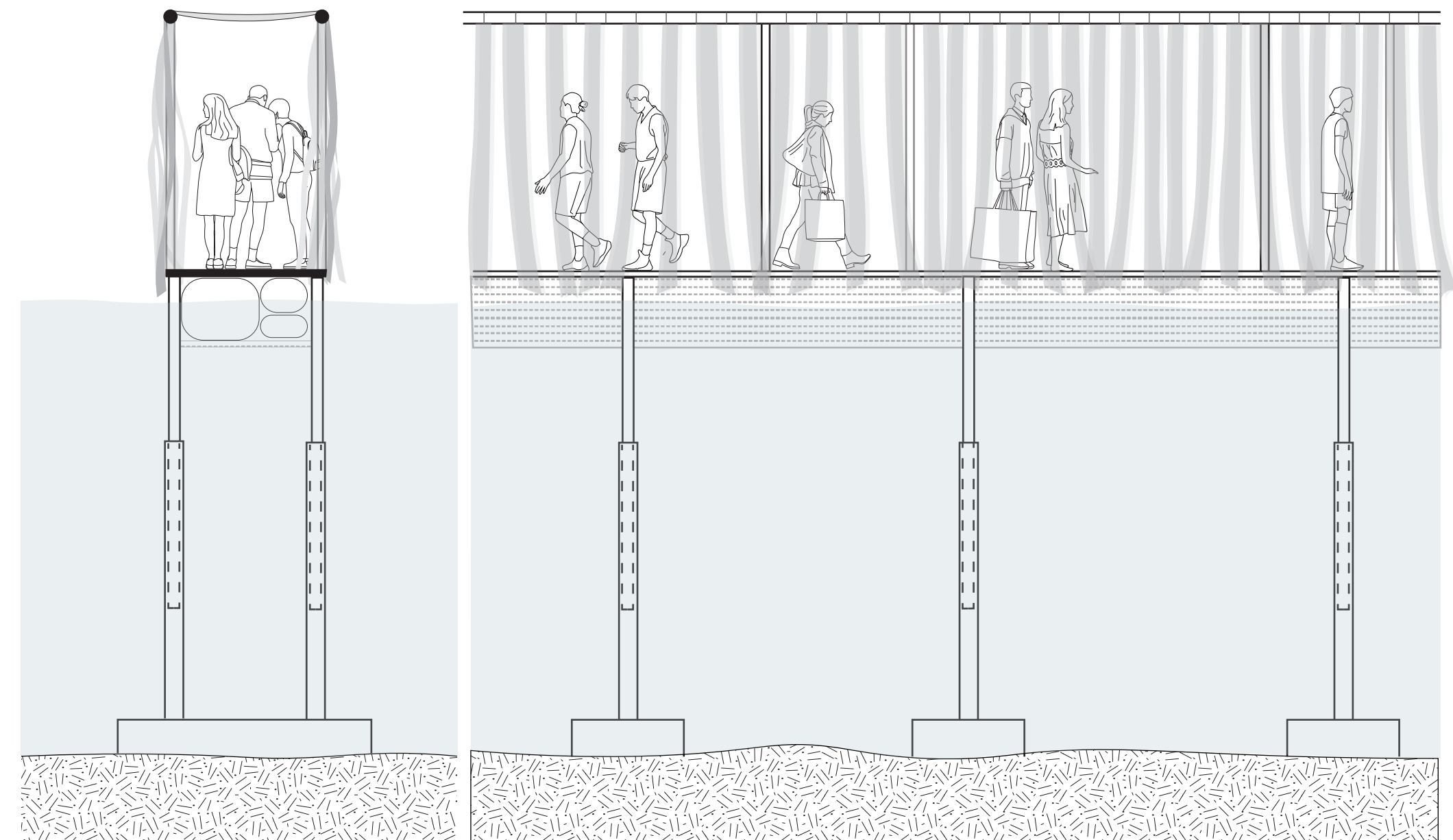
Concrete Piles

The theatre structures are all supported with a thin concrete pile grid system. These concrete piles include small notches and divots that encourage marine life, such as oysters, to attach fostering a haven for sealife in Berry's Bay. The toxic sludge settled at the bottom of the bay is constantly at risk of being dredged up by motorboats passing by, but blocking this area underneath the structure keeps the water clearer and more sympathetic to marine life and their survival.

Floating Pathways

The pathways linking the theatres gently float atop the water, preserving a physical connection between visitors and the water as it rises and falls with the tides.

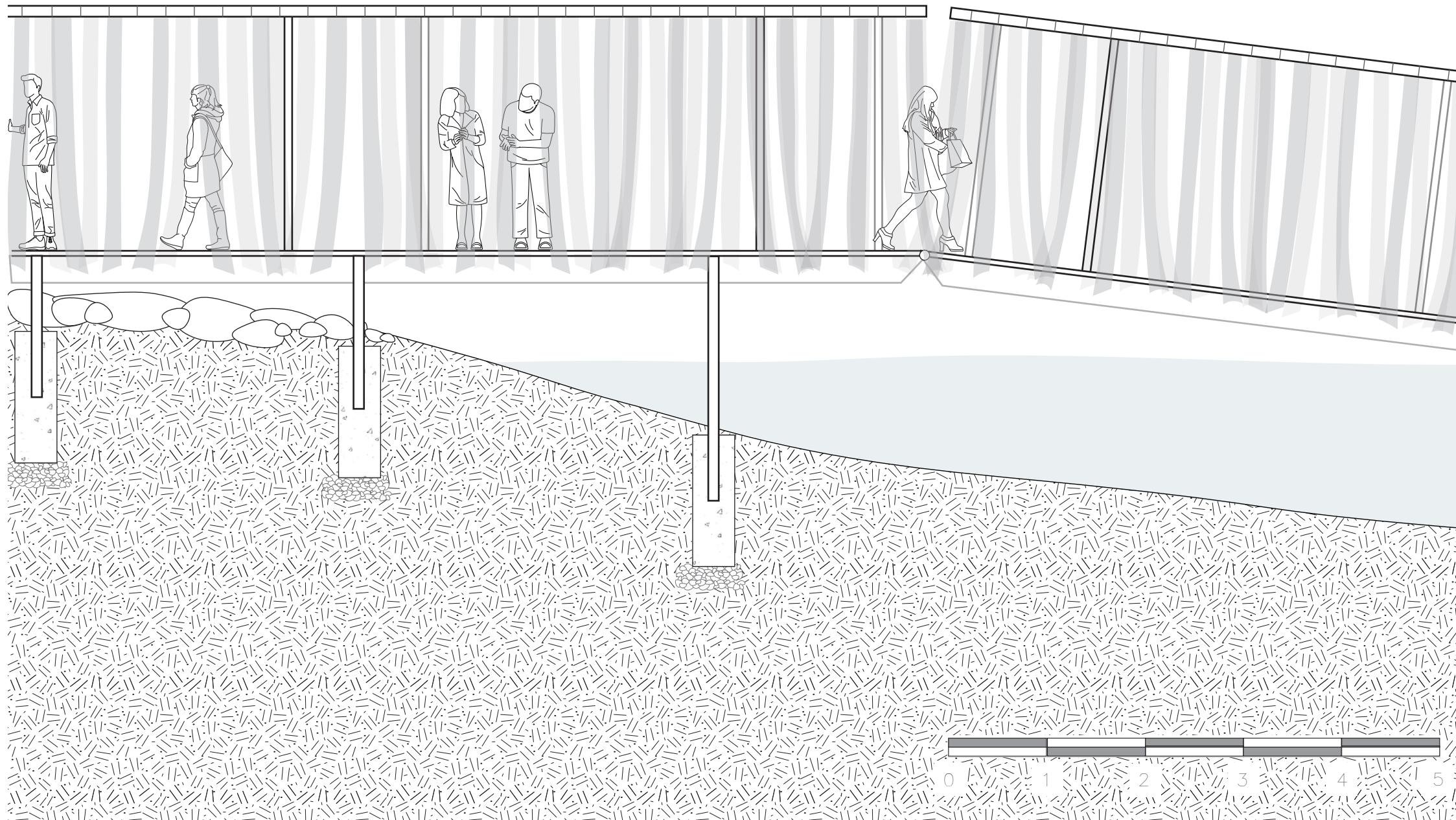
To maintain the positioning while accommodating vertical movement, the paths are anchored by a system of steel poles that slide smoothly within fixed sleeves, ensuring they remain in place. Beneath the pathway, a mesh frame holds recycled plastic containers that provide buoyancy, supporting the structure's floating design.



Section

Elevation





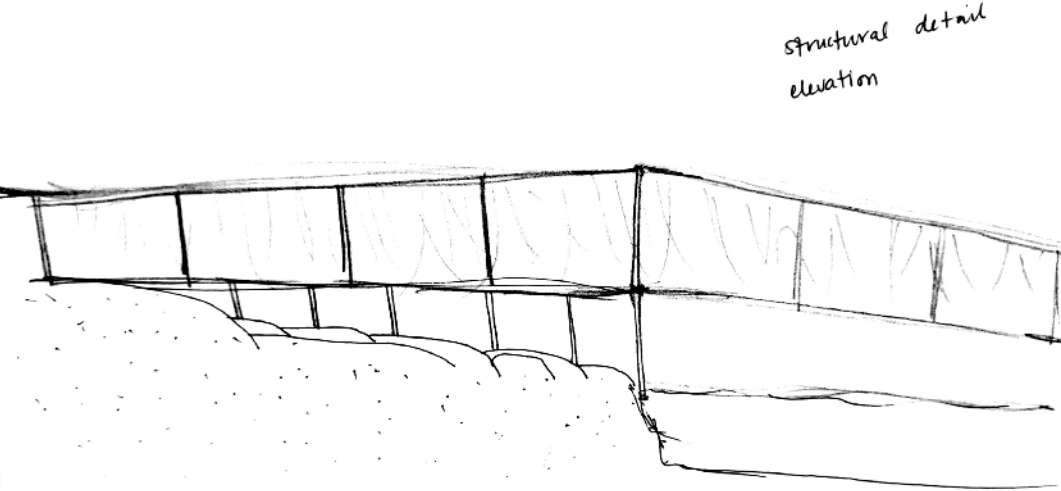
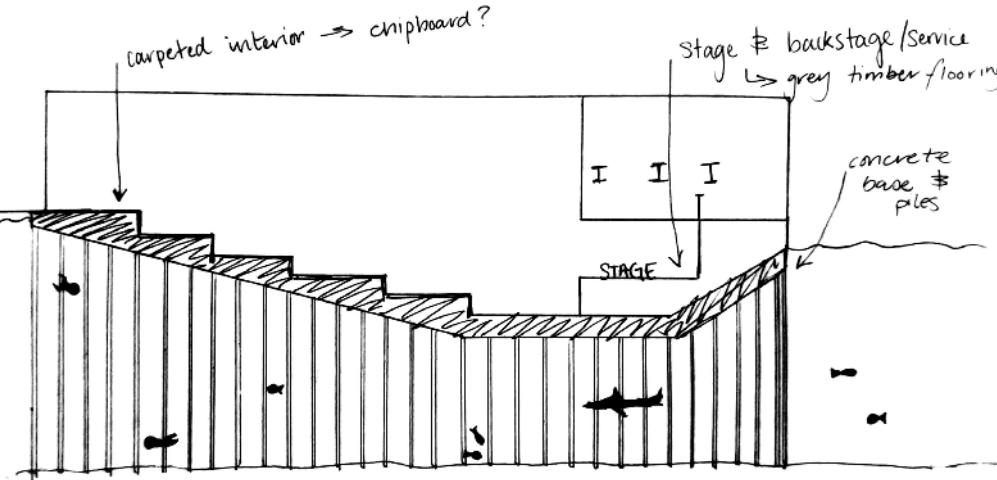
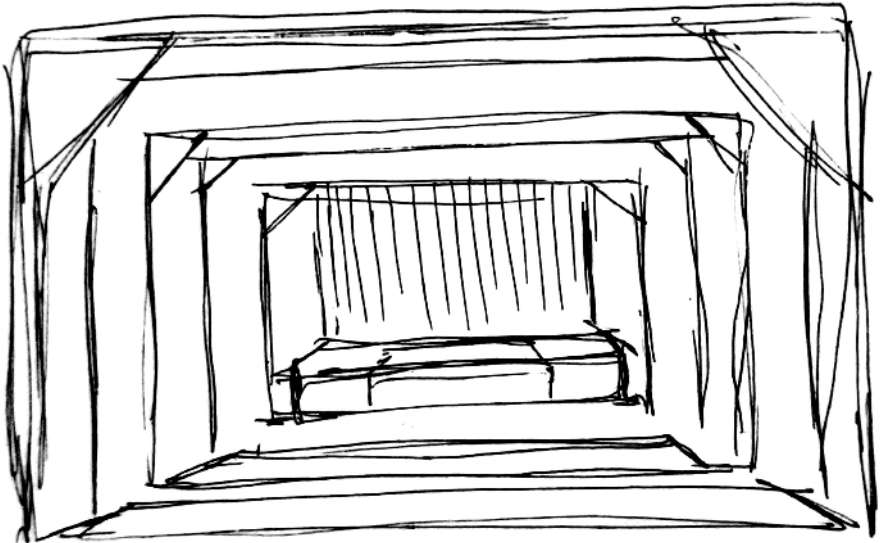
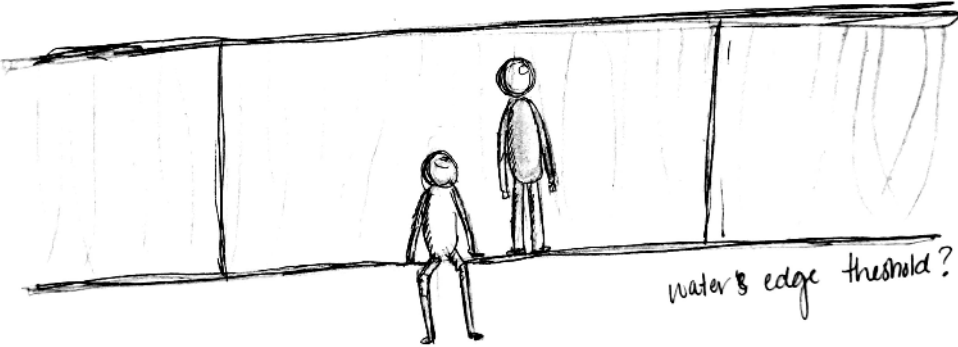
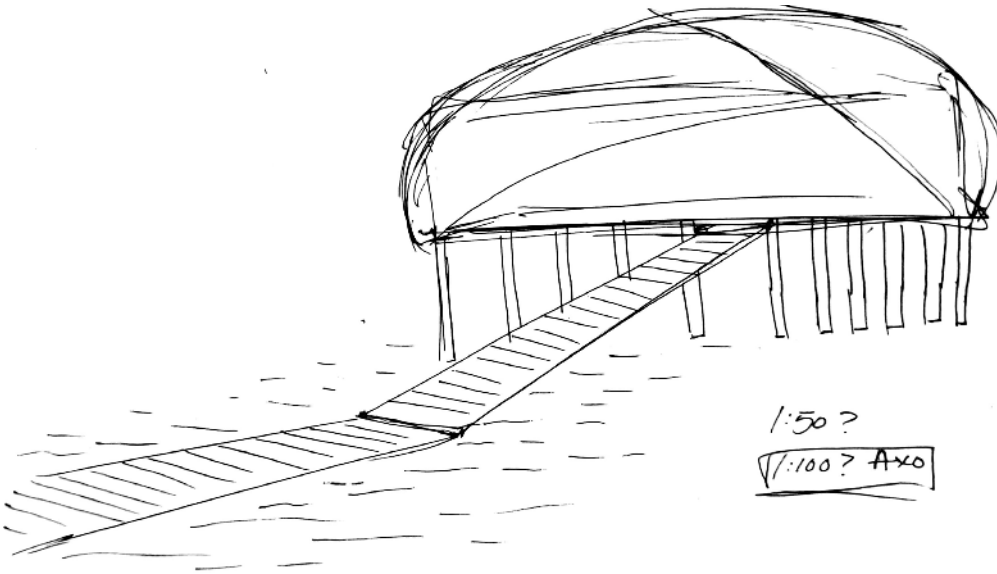
Connection to Land

To accommodate the height difference between the fixed land pathway and the floating pathways during low tides, a long, straight transitional section is placed at each junction. Supported by a robust steel structure, this section spans 14m, allowing it to achieve the necessary ramp ratio even at the maximum height difference of 0.9m.

PART SIX:

CONCLUSION

Initial Concept Sketches



The Driftwood Theatre

The floating theatre design was conceived to harmonise with its surrounding bushy landscape and serve as a hidden gem along a desire path through the reserve. This design plays with the concepts of concealment and revelation, creating an experience that immerses visitors in nature while gradually unveiling the theatre's structure. The journey to the theatre begins along a long, winding pathway that lays low to the water's surface. This pathway is not just a means of transportation but an integral part of the experience, designed to fully envelop visitors in the natural environment. As they walk, they are surrounded by the sights, sounds, and smells of the water, becoming immersed in the moment, disconnected from the urban world they have left behind.

Adding to this immersive experience, semi-transparent cloth is hung around the walkway, creating a sense of enclosure. This design choice prevents visitors from seeing too far ahead, encouraging them to focus on their immediate surroundings and experience each step of their journey in the moment. The cloth subtly shifts with the breeze, allowing glimpses of the natural world outside but never revealing the full view ahead. This intentional design fosters a sense of mystery and anticipation, heightening the experience of discovery as visitors progress along the path.

The theatre itself, once reached, continues this theme of concealment and revelation. The structure is designed to cut down into the water, ensuring it remains low and seamlessly integrated with the surrounding landscape. From a distance, the building is almost unrecognisable, blending in with the natural surroundings and making it unclear that it is, in fact, a theatre. This subtle design allows the theatre to be discovered rather than announced, turning it into a hidden treasure from within the reserve.

Outdoor spaces within the theatre are partially enclosed by sails, a nod to the site's long maritime history. These sails, made from materials reminiscent of the industrial past, create a dynamic interplay of light and shadow while offering partial views of the harbour. Through the gaps in the sails, visitors catch fleeting glimpses of the water and the performers as they make their way to smaller, more intimate stages. This design element reinforces the sense of discovery, as the theatre's full beauty and purpose are gradually revealed to those who explore it.

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